in an army-engineered 'parliamentary coup' in April 2022, and Munir, backed by a ruling coalition opposed to Imran, became the army chief that November. Months later, Munir had Imran jailed on multiple charges of corruption that saw the former prime minister sentenced to 14 years in prison early this year.

Decoding Asim Munir

Studying Munir's personality traits, psychological make-up, strengths and weaknesses has become central to India's strategy to deliver a fitting riposte to Pakistan for the carnage it instigated in Pahalgam. Munir heads a formidable, half-million-strong, Pakistan army—the sixth largest in the world—which also has nuclear weapons and is evenly matched with Indian troops on the Line of Control.

INDIA WILL FIND IT DIFFICULT TO CONTROL THE ESCALATION LADDER, AS MUNIR'S RECENT ACTIONS HAVE BEEN FULL OF SURPRISES

As a top expert, who does not wish to be named, puts it, "This is not an asymmetric war like Israel vs Hamas or Azerbaijan vs Armenia. This is between two of the most professional armies who are equally matched and have nuclear capabilities. Anything we do, we should expect him to retaliate. Controlling the escalation ladder of conflict will not be easy. Judging by Munir's recent actions, we should be prepared for unpredictability and surprises, including him initiating something and blaming us for it."

With Munir being the rare Pakistani general to have been chief of ISI as well as the Director General of Military Intelligence, he is expected to have thought through his strategy well. It was evident in Pakistan's instantaneous suspension of the 1972 Simla agreement in response to India's decision to hold the Indus Waters Treaty (IWT) in abeyance. Another strategist familiar with the process of war gaming points out, "Munir would have gamed all options beforehand and is moving with greater caution than normal. We need to carefully gauge him, as he has extensive intelligence and operational exposure. It's like a game of chess in which we need to think 10 steps ahead of him along with our own contingency plans and punches. So, we have to keep second-guessing his moves till we have some tentative answers at least. Specialists also need to do a detailed psychological profiling based on his behaviour and statements."

There are enough clues in Munir's 17-month tenure that showcase his ability to take calculated and calibrated risks. In the beginning, he was on the back foot given the unprecedented internal dissent in the ranks over Imran's arrest. But Munir ruthlessly consolidated his hold over the army, purging even the corps commanders who opposed him and replacing them with loyalists. Since then, he

THE RISE AND RISE OF A GENERAL

BIRTH AND FAMILY

Syed Asim Munir Ahmed Shah was born in Rawalpindi. His father, Syed Sarwar Munir, whose family had migrated from Jalandhar after Partition, was a schoolteacher, and also served as an imam, delivering Friday sermons at a local mosque. Asim Munir studied at Markazi Madrasa Dar-ul-Tajweed in Rawalpindi. Later, he would earn the title of a Hafiz-i-Quran for having memorised all the verses of the Quran in their entirety.



JOINING THE ARMY

Munir did not join the elite Pakistan Military Academy but entered service through the Officers Training School (OTS) at Mangla in 1986. As the best-performing cadet (in photo), he won the Sword of Honour. His first posting was in the 23rd Battalion of the Frontier Force Regiment, an infantry unit.

MUNIR'S POWER



Asif Ali Zardari
President



Shehbaz Sharif
Prime Minister

KEY ARMY COMMANDERS
Lieutenant Generals Muhammad Avais Dastgir (V Corps), Shahid Imtiaz (X Corps), Syed Omer Ahmed Bokhari